

Watching Erotic Movies Together Is Not For Everyone



DR. SANDRA
SCANTLING
INTIMACY, SEX
& RELATIONSHIP

Wendy and Phil are an average couple in their late 40s who are sexually stuck and finally decided to see a sex therapist.

Phil is a soft-spoken accountant — a numbers man. He has thinning gray-brown hair and a benign appearance. As he speaks, Wendy,

soft-featured and rotund, fidgets with the zipper of her pink fleece warm-up jacket.

They both say that they have a “wonderful” marriage, are great business partners and terrific parents, but their sex life is incredibly boring. Phil wonders about his lack of experience. “Neither of us has had sex with anyone else — we really have no means for comparison.”

As Phil talks, Wendy nods in agreement. She shares that they only make love in the dark and in the missionary position.

“Wendy doesn’t let me see her naked and isn’t much on experimentation,” Phil adds sheepishly. “She undresses in the bathroom and covers up with those granny nightgowns.”

Wendy interjects, as if in her defense, “I’ve put on a few pounds since the baby

was born” (their “baby” will be 12 this year). “Phil buys me sexy lingerie,” she admits, looking perplexed, “but it just stays in the bureau drawer.” They would both like to feel more comfortable sexually and break out of their rut, but like so many couples, they’re unsure how to start.

At the end of our first session, as we’re walking toward the door, Phil asks, “Do you think getting a porn movie would be a good idea, doc?” I glance at Wendy, who is beet red.

“I really can’t answer that with a simple yes or no,” I say. “If it’s OK with you, let’s discuss it next time.”

At our second session, Phil immediately raises the issue of getting a sex movie. Wendy is more open to the idea than he would have thought, with some reservations.

With a little direction, they discuss their differences in tastes, what’s acceptable and what’s totally off limits. Wendy is uncharacteristically vocal about her objection to any scenes containing domination or submission or what she sees as “subjugation” of women. Phil adds that he doesn’t want to see a series of random sex acts without a story line (I usually hear that comment from women). The longer they speak, the more they discover about one another.

Even though they’ve been together for

16 years, they haven’t ever explored many of their private sexual preferences.

When I ask if they have any concerns about seeing an explicit video together, Phil discloses that he is worried about not comparing well with the male actors. “What if they have a much bigger . . . you know . . . and what if they last a long time?” He’s apparently been secretly concerned about “finishing” too quickly and not satisfying Wendy. She immediately reassures him that this is not the case.

At the conclusion of their discussion, they decide to begin with a “softer” erotic film like “9½ Weeks” or “Unfaithful.” They also agree to turn off anything disturbing to either of them.

On the day after their “movie experience,” Wendy and Phil set aside some time to talk. They feel like pioneers who have conquered some unexplored territory. They discuss what made them feel aroused and what made them feel uncomfortable. They even select something new they’d like to do together. For them, this novel experience has had an unexpectedly positive intimacy-enhancing outcome.

Not everyone has this experience. Discovering the subtleties of what is personally objectionable in this context isn’t easy or even conscious. You may

not know what you don’t like until you see it. One partner’s turn-on may be another’s serious turn-off. A steamy love scene may stimulate his imagination, but gynecological close-ups may shut down her enthusiasm. Watching perfect bodies engaged in gymnastic feats of sexual prowess may do more to threaten than to stimulate. These well-endowed folks aren’t usually selected for their acting ability. It’s important to keep in mind that you’re seeing edited footage, often not shot in real time. In fact, some of the activities are just on one continuous loop.

It’s important not to confuse hard-core pornography with softer erotica or instructional sex videos. There are dozens of sensitively produced products that offer tasteful, educational and entertaining alternatives to sexual enhancement. They demonstrate affection, playfulness and creativity without objectifying or demeaning either partner. In recent years, these films have made a special effort to include images, relationships and themes designed especially for women and same sex partners.

So before you rush out to your local video store, speak openly and honestly with your partner. Don’t assume that things will just naturally fall into place. The surprise you excitedly bring home

as a hopeful aphrodisiac may backfire.

Watching erotica isn’t for everyone. It can stimulate feelings of anxiety or inadequacy. It can cross over issues of politics, gender preferences, legality, aesthetics and more. Good communication is key.

If you do decide to experiment with erotica, take the experience with several grains of salt — films foster fantasy. If we could all frolic endlessly on a lush, secluded tropical island — without cares about children or other responsibilities, there would be much more spectacular sex.

Watching an evocative or explicit movie together is just one way to invigorate your sexual repertoire, but it is not a panacea.

It will never replace the good old hard work necessary for satisfying intimate relationships.

Dr. Sandra Scantling is a licensed clinical psychologist and certified sex therapist. She practices in Farmington. You may e-mail her at AskDrScantling@aol.com. This column is not intended as a substitute for professional, medical or psychological advice, diagnosis or treatment. Case material used here includes composites and is not intended to represent any actual couple or individual.